

YOUTH

THE NEW SURGE

An election where the youth vote played a pivotal role sent the largest number of young MPs to Parliament in 25 years

Welcome to the Cub Class. With as many as 82 MPs falling in the 25-40 age bracket, this Parliament has the largest collection of young faces in 25 years. It's a curious mix of professionals, dynasts and political wives, with a couple of actors thrown in. Then again, what is Parliament without the theatrics? They are young and earnest. And they have arrived at the doorstep of India's most powerful institution. Though some are still to lose their public school accent, a long and gruelling campaign has taught them the right rhetoric. A London School of Economics graduate, Jayant Chaudhary says he wants to focus on 'agricultural development'; Dr Jyoti Mirdha whose favourite mode of communication is the Internet says that she would like to do something for the girl child and rural health while the feisty Shruti Choudhry is busy crafting her Obama moment, saying that she wants to make a change.

The rhetoric is not new. What makes it refreshing, however, is the enthusiasm with which it is delivered. It's an idealism that is yet to be marred by cynicism. Though Choudhary had been to Parliament earlier to watch his father Ajit Singh, but it was as a visitor. "Going there as an MP is a lot different," he says, still savouring the heady euphoria of the biggest win of his life. Parliament's youngest MP Hamdullah Sayeed simply says that he is "delighted and happy to be here". It is almost as if he was at a social gathering and not participating in the world's largest democracy. For all of them, the moment is still to sink in, and with it the weight of responsibility. The second-time MPs have a 'been-there, done-that' attitude at all this wide-eyed wonder. The Congress, of course, has the biggest chunk with 27 young faces. Then again, this is the era of Rahul Gandhi where to be young is to be politically correct. At least, in the Congress. After all, eight out of the 10 Youth Congress candidates fielded by Rahul have won.

With 15 per cent of the electorate between 18 to 30, this is also an election where the young voter played a pivotal role. And the young it seems have placed faith among their own kind. But will they be able to deliver? This is a system that works on patronage and tradition rather than initiative and enterprise. Another first-timer, Meenakshi Natrajan, however, seems to disagree. A non-dynast and rising star in Rahul's youth brigade, she points that though she was advised to fight her election on the caste plank, she refused and talked development instead. And won. Maybe young Shruti is right. After 26/11, the disillusionment with politics as usual is at an all-time low. If there is a time when the young can make a difference, it is now. Their time has come.

by Priya Sahgal

AFTER 26/11, FAITH IN POLITICIANS WAS AT AN ALL-TIME LOW. THE TIME IS RIGHT FOR THE YOUNG TO BRING IN CHANGE.



RAVI S SAHANI

HAMDULLAH SAYEED

Lakshadweep, Congress

26 years

The Delhi High Court lawyer and late P.M. Sayeed's son is the youngest MP



MANDAR DEODHAR

NILESH RANE

Maharashtra, Ratnagiri Congress

27 years

Narayan Rane's son defeated his father's bete noire Suresh Prabhu



SIPRA DAS

MAUSAM NOOR

West Bengal, Malda (North) Congress

28 years

A law graduate, Ghani Khan Choudhury's niece was Sonia's choice